ACHIEVERS

VIJAYA PAWAR, 39

Entrepreneur, Banjara handicrafts, Gorbanjara tribe

In a bid to revive the languishing Gormati art, Vijaya Pawar formed an NGO in 2004, the Harappani Gorbanjara Mahila Kala Vikas Mandal, which has trained hundreds of tribal women to make Banjara handicraft products and earn a good living. A silent worker, Pawar achieved instant fame after PM Narendra Modi chose her among the women achievers to take over his social media handle on International Women's Day in 2020. A winner of two international awards, Pawar hopes to take her brand 'Pono' global in the near future.

"BANJARA WOMEN NEED TO BE ENCOURAGED. THE STEREOTYPES ARE THE MAIN HURDLE IN EMPOWERING THEM"



Photograph by MANDAR DEODHAR



Photograph by AJEEB KOMACHI

SHREEDHANYA SURESH, 29

IAS officer, Kurichiya tribe

Sreedhanya's daily-wage labourer parents in Kerala's Wayanad district worked hard to educate their three children. After completing her postgrad, Sreedhanya met IAS officer S. Sambasiva Rao while working for the tribal development department. Motivated by him, she appeared for the civil services examination, which she cracked in 2018—the first tribal woman from Kerala to do so. Now the sub-collector and sub-divisional magistrate in Perinthalmanna, Malappuram district, she is an inspiration for her community.

"DEVELOPMENT IN TRIBAL AREAS SHOULD HAVE A NOVEL APPROACH THAT HONOURS THE TRADITIONS AND PRACTICES OF THE COMMUNITY"